



Staging Parity Runbook

Central Intelligence · **Release gate** · Virtual Assistants Philippines · 2026

Every productization phase (instance profile, prompt templating, sync engine, configurable directors, ...) must prove it changes **nothing** for the current client before it reaches production. This runbook is that gate. The baseline production state is tagged `v1.0-greg-baseline`.

1. The three parity checks

CHECK	WHAT IT FREEZES	HOW TO RUN
Prompt snapshots	Every module-level prompt constant (32 constants, 24 modules)	<code>tests.parity.test_prompt_snapshots</code>
Row counts	COUNT(*) for all 62 ORM tables	<code>scripts.capture_parity_baseline --check</code>
Metric values	All registry metrics' (value, sample_size) over fixed windows (all-time + since 2026-06-01)	

Full commands, run from `backend/` :

```
# prompt snapshots
PYTHONPATH=. .venv/bin/python -m tests.parity.test_prompt_snapshots

# row counts + metric values
PYTHONPATH=. .venv/bin/python -m scripts.capture_parity_baseline --check
```

Fixtures live in `backend/tests/parity/fixtures/`. The baseline production state is tagged `v1.0-greg-baseline`.

- **Prompt snapshots are data-independent** — they must pass on any checkout, any machine, no DB needed. Run them on every branch before merging.
- **Row counts / metric values are data-dependent** — the live DB drifts by design (hourly WGR sync). A `--check` is only meaningful against a frozen copy of the data, which the staging procedure below provides.

2. Creating a staging clone

Local restore of a production dump (preferred — cheap, disposable):

1. **Dump the app DB** (read-only; use the transaction pooler, port 6543):

```
pg_dump "$PARITY_DATABASE_URL" -Fc -f .tmp/ci_prod.dump
```

2. **Restore locally** into Postgres 15+ with pgvector:

```
createdb ci_staging && \  
pg_restore -d ci_staging --no-owner .tmp/ci_prod.dump
```

3. **Point a staging env at it** — copy `backend/.env` to `backend/.env.staging` and edit, then run the API/scripts with it.

REQUIRED STAGING OVERRIDES — THESE MAKE THE CLONE INERT

- `DATABASE_URL` — set to the local `ci_staging` DB
- `CLIENT_SYNC_ENABLED=false` — never sync into staging
- `INTEGRATIONS_ENCRYPTION_KEY` — set to a **freshly generated** Fernet key, so restored third-party credentials are unreadable and no job can accidentally call Mailchimp/Meta/Google from staging
- `MOCK_MODE=true` unless a test explicitly needs live LLM calls (keeps Anthropic/Voyage spend at zero)

Alternative when full-stack behavior matters (Caddy, compose, beat): snapshot the DO droplet, restore to a throwaway droplet, apply the same env overrides, destroy it when done.

3. Release gate procedure (per phase)

STEP 1 · REFRESH FIXTURES AGAINST THE OLD CODE

On the staging clone, freeze what “unchanged” means for this data snapshot.

Check out the last released tag (first time: `v1.0-greg-baseline`), then run `capture_parity_baseline` with `PARITY_DATABASE_URL` pointing at the staging DB.

STEP 2 · RUN THE CHECKS ON THE RELEASE CANDIDATE

Check out the release-candidate branch (same staging DB) and run all four checks.

- `tests.parity.test_prompt_snapshots` — prompts identical (or intentionally regenerated in the same PR, with the diff reviewed)
- `capture_parity_baseline --check` — counts and metrics identical
- the full test suite (`tests/test_*.py`)
- chat smoke test: ask the orchestrator + each director one real business question; answers must cite the same numbers as before

STEP 3 · SHIP – ONLY ON GREEN

Tag the release, merge to org main, sync the mirror, redeploy, verify the frontend.

Only on green: tag the release, merge to org `main`, sync the `va-jeanne-ai` mirror, redeploy the droplet, verify Vercel shows **Ready** — frontend deploys fail silently on lint, so run `npm run build` locally first.

4. When a parity change is intentional

A phase that *means* to change something (e.g. Phase 1 moves a benchmark sentence between prompt files) regenerates the affected fixture **in the same PR** and the fixture diff is reviewed like code — the diff IS the proof of exactly what changed:

```
UPDATE_PARITY_FIXTURES=1 PYTHONPATH=. \
  .venv/bin/python -m tests.parity.test_prompt_snapshots
```